Wherever you travel in Tamil Nadu or Kerala in December you are bound to meet groups of wild-looking men on the move, in trains or buses or on the roads. They are instantly recognisable as well as unavoidable: barefoot, unshaven, some with painted faces, clad in blue, black or saffron *lungi*s (lengths of cotton cloth worn as loincloths) and little else besides necklaces of tulsi beads. At first sight they can look alarming. You could even mistake them for rowdies who have had too much country liquor, because they are invariably in high spirits, chanting, dancing and banging drums as they go. However, far from being drunk, they are actually undergoing a forty-one-day period of fasting, during which they abstain from alcohol, meat, tobacco and sex. Their unmistakable good cheer identifies them as devotees of Lord Ayyappan. These pilgrims are all heading either to or from the Ayyappan temple of Sabarimala.

Until quite recently the Sabarimala temple was one of the most isolated shrines in Kerala, located deep in the forests of the Western Ghats some 100 kilometres inland from Alleppey (or Alappuzha, as it is now known). For years it was accessible only by two days' walking along forest tracks and so received few pilgrims. But following the elections of a series of left-wing governments from the late 1960s onwards a tarmac road (now National Highway 220) was driven through the mountains to connect Kollam in Kerala with Theni in Tamil Nadu. Today the Sabarimala temple claims to receive a staggering thirty million pilgrims a year. A more realistic estimate would be about five million – which is still a phenomenal figure that places Sabarimala at the top of South India's pilgrimage league.

What makes these statistics even more staggering is that these devotees are almost entirely made up of men, since no woman between the ages of ten and fifty is allowed to mount the sacred *pathinettampady*, a stairway of eighteen steps that gives access to the main platform of the temple. This is on the grounds that women have menstrual cycles